

Finally, be careful of the concept of a “good deal.” “75% off” isn’t a “good deal” if you don’t need it.

TRICKS OF THE TRADE

Once you are organized, learn some tricks of the trade to really save money.

Pair store coupons with manufacturer’s coupons. The majority of stores allow you to top off their own store coupon savings with your manufacturer coupons. Look at the top of the coupon in your store ad. Does it say “store coupon” or “manufacturer’s coupon” next to the expiration date? If it says “manufacturer’s coupon” then you can’t use another manufacturer’s coupon along with it, but if it is clearly labeled as a store coupon, you can combine the savings and really make out like a bandit, sometimes netting totally free products. If you are shopping at a store you’ve never been in before, don’t just assume you can use two coupons—ask a manager. The cashier might tell you “no” even when the store’s policy allows it, so it is best to ask at the customer service counter or request a manager’s input.

Watch for sales when a coupon for a new product comes out. Frequently a manufacturer will introduce a new product with both a coupon blitz and sale prices to entice consumers to try their product. By watching the ads, a savvy couponer will wait for the sale to use the coupon, netting nearly free products. Not only that, but I’ve discovered that some of these new products will clearance out fairly quickly, either because the product idea didn’t fly (anyone remember green ketchup?) or the original retail